

Narrating Male Childhood Trauma in Elnathan John's *Born on a Tuesday* and Novuyo Tshuma's *House of Stone*

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Abstract

Existing scholarly debates on childhood trauma have acknowledged the prevalence of violence as a recurring feature the African child battles in postcolonial Africa. While many examined the female child, few have concentrated on the depiction of male childhood violence in Africa neglecting how literary resources suggest personal pains as collective pain. To address this, the study examines the portrayal of male childhood trauma in Elnathan John's *Born on a Tuesday* (*BOAT*) and Novuyo Tshuma's *House of Stone* (*HOS*) with a view to describing the socio-political catalysts of male childhood trauma and to analyse the narrative techniques used to depict the psychological fragmentation of the victims in the selected novels. The study applies Stef Crap's Trauma theory. The texts were published in 21st century and purposively selected for their depiction of loss of childhood innocence. The study reveals that the socio-political triggers are internal and external violence. The implications are loss of agency and physical displacement erasure of identity and psychological manipulation. In *BOAT*, masculinity serves as a tool for political and religious militia. In *HOS*, it serves as a vessel for inherited national trauma. The study contributes to broader conversations on postcolonial trauma, mental health and studies on contemporary narratives.

Key words: Male childhood trauma, Child narrator, Displacement, Masculinity and Agency

Introduction

Contemporary African literature has gradually moved away from nostalgic portrayals of childhood innocence toward more complex representations of children formed by violence, displacement, poverty and political instability. Within this shifting literary landscape, the figure of the male child has become significant as writers examine how masculinity is formed, disrupted and redefined under traumatic conditions. Instead of presenting the male child as naturally resilient or emotionally invulnerable, many African writers depict him as vulnerable subjects caught within the system of postcolonial disillusion. Childhood, therefore, becomes an important lens through which African literature reflects on the wider crises of the postcolonial African nation-state.

The coming-of-age narrative in African literature often functions as a metaphor for the troubled growth of the postcolonial nation itself (Ogaga, 2009). The suffering experienced by children frequently mirrors the failures of governance, unresolved historical violence and social fragmentation that characterise many African societies. Although scholars (Alcinda 2006, Ofusu-Kusi and Abebe 2016, Conell, Ahmed 2022) have widely acknowledged childhood trauma as a recurring feature in African literature, studies (Okpiliya and Archibong 2021, Ajidahun 2020, Murray 2017, Mohammed 2010, Lugano 2005) have largely focused on the experiences of the female child, especially in relation to patriarchy, domestic abuse and gender oppression. However, the traumatic

experiences of male children remain underexplored despite the prevalence of violence directed at the male child in many postcolonial African contexts.

Recent scholarship, however, has begun to address this gap by examining how African literary texts represent male vulnerability, emotional repression and fractured masculine identities. Scholars increasingly recognise that the male child in postcolonial African societies is often exposed to violence through several experiences. These experiences influence his psychological development and identity formation, while it challenges cultural assumptions that equate masculinity with strength, emotional control and endurance. These challenges can culminate into traumatic situations.

Early trauma studies are heavily influenced by the work of Caruth (1996) who defines trauma as a psychological wound that returns belatedly through memory, silence, and repetition. However, postcolonial scholars have criticised the Eurocentric orientation of early trauma theory for universalising Western experiences, while neglecting the collective and historical realities of formerly colonised societies. In response to this limitation, Craps (2013) advocates the decolonisation of trauma studies by foregrounding non-Western experiences of suffering, displacement, and political violence. Craps argues that trauma in postcolonial societies must be understood within broader histories of colonialism, economic instability, communal violence and state oppression.

Scholarship on African masculinities also sheds light on the relationship between trauma and male identity formation. African masculinities examine how colonial histories, patriarchy, violence, and socio-economic instability shape masculine identities across African societies (Morrell and Ouzgane, 2005). This challenges the essentialist assumptions that masculinity is associated with strength and emotional invulnerability. Instead, masculinity is presented as socially constructed and deeply vulnerable to trauma.

Recent studies have increasingly focused on violence against male children in African fiction. Omini's study on the representation of violence against the male child investigates how African literary texts portray institutional abuse, familial violence, traditional oppression, and psychological trauma experienced by male children. Through analyses of texts such as Chinua Achebe's *Things Fall Apart*, Chimamanda Adichie's *Purple Hibiscus*, Uzodinma Iweala's *Beasts of No Nation*, Omini argues that African fiction exposes the silenced vulnerabilities of male children within patriarchal and postcolonial systems (Omini, 2024). Similarly, examination of traumatic memory in *Things Fall Apart* reveals how childhood neglect shapes violent adult masculinities. Okonkwo's traumatic childhood contributes significantly to his aggression and toxic masculinity in adulthood and this demonstrates how unresolved childhood trauma reproduces violence across generations (Onuoha, 2023; Ojekanmi, 2026).

Contemporary African fiction also increasingly explores trauma alongside resilience and survival. Scholars such as Chikamadu, Nwachukwu-Agbada, Emezue (2026) argue that African adolescent fiction often portrays young characters not simply as passive victims but as survivors who negotiate trauma through resilience and identity reconstruction. This critical shift broadens trauma narrative beyond victimhood to include agency and recovery, thereby showing writers' active engagement with characters.

Despite these interventions, significant gaps remain in studies of male childhood trauma in African literature. While feminist scholarship has extensively examined female childhood trauma, comparatively little attention has been given to the male child

emotional vulnerability and psychological fragmentation. It is within this gap that Elnathan John's *Born on a Tuesday* and Tshuma's *House of Stone* become important. Both novels explore the "stunting" of masculinity through the lens of various lens. In *BOAT*, John situates his narrative within the religious and political tensions of Northern Nigeria. Similarly, *House of Stone* examines the haunting legacies of Zimbabwe's Gukurahundi massacres and the psychological debris left behind by postcolonial state violence.

Anchored in trauma theory, this study narrates male childhood trauma in *Born on a Tuesday* and *House of Stone*. The study interrogates how the selected novels portray the socio-political catalysts of traumatised male children. To achieve this, the study seeks to answer the following research questions: What are the socio-political catalysts of male childhood trauma in the selected novels and how do the selected novels represent the implications of male childhood trauma in adulthood? These questions guide the examination of the representation of male childhood trauma and its long-term consequences in the selected texts.

Methodology

Elnathan John's *Born on a Tuesday* and Tshuma's *House of Stone* are purposively selected for their depiction of interior lives of the identified protagonists, loss of childhood innocence and the effect of socio-political unrest on the male child's identity and mental well-being. The texts were published in the contemporary era (2000 onwards). *BOAT* was published in 2016 and *HOS* was published in 2018. Both texts represent West Africa: Nigeria and Zimbabwe. Both narratives are voiced by male protagonists. The selected novels are closely read and manifestations of traumatic experiences of male children are identified and described. *BOAT* focuses on the story of a young boy who is offered by his parents to pursue Islamic itinerant education (almariji), while *HOS* examines the haunting legacies of Zimbabwe's Gukurahundi massacres and the psychological debris left behind by postcolonial state violence.

Childhood Studies in Africa and Male Childhood Trauma

Studies on childhood in Africa have increasingly moved beyond universalist and Eurocentric models of development to emphasize the socio-cultural, political, and historical specificity of African childhoods. Childhood is no longer treated as a fixed biological stage dictated by innocence and protection but rather as a socially constructed. These experiences are by poverty, conflict, kinship systems, and postcolonial governance structures (Honwana 2006; Ogaga, 2009).

Allison James and Alan Prout (1997) reinforce the idea that childhood is not a universal category but one produced through cultural and institutional discourses. In African contexts, this means that childhood is often shaped by communal responsibility, economic participation and early exposure to adult roles. This perspective shows how the African male child is denied the luxury of prolonged innocence; instead, he is inserted early into systems of labour and violence.

In addition, Honwana (2006) concept of "waithood" describes the prolonged and unstable transition from childhood to adulthood in contexts of economic hardship and political instability. Honwana (2006) shows that children in conflict zones are often

compelled to assume adult responsibilities prematurely, thereby disrupting normative developmental trajectories. This childhood is characterised by precarity rather than protection. Honwana (2005) assert that children are both agents and subjects of structural transformation. His assertion challenges the dominant victim-centred narratives by emphasising that children have the capacity to act and negotiate their environments even under conditions of extreme constraint. Children actively interpret and respond to their environments, even under conditions of extreme adversity. This emphasis on agency is important for reading male child characters who are not merely acted upon by trauma, but also participate in survival strategies that may include adaptation, silence or moral compromise.

Masculinity studies further deepen this analysis by interrogating how male childhood is constructed by gendered expectations. Connell (1995) theory of hegemonic masculinity is particularly influential in understanding how male children are socialised into ideals of strength, emotional restraint and authority. In African postcolonial contexts, these expectations are often intensified by conflict and instability, producing masculinities that are closely tied to violence and survival.

A plethora of studies have investigated the plights surrounding the physical, emotional existence of the African child. These studies have prominently articulated the deployment of diverse literary theories in investigating the construction of the African child. Studies in this category include those of Cazenva (2005), Kearney (2014) Thandokazi (2013), Ndlovu, (2014), Ugwuanyi (2020) Kalampung (2021) Ahmed (2022) Adesola (2022) Ofor (2023). From the literary stylistic perspective, Thandozaki (2013) examines the stylistic devices adopted by African writers in constructing the realities around the African child. The study investigates the literary stylistics of three African writers namely: No Violet, Uwem Akpan and Miacouto. The study's adoption of qualitative analysis shows that these writers deploy child narration techniques, vivid images and omniscient narrating technique. The study notes that these stylistic devices are used to report the harrowing socio-economic, physical and psychological trauma surrounding the African child.

Cazenva (2005) notes that violence against children is not a new reality in African novels. Ahmed (2022) surmises that African novelists explore the agonies of the African child to reflect how the historical context defines the realities around the African child. He notes African novelists deploy prosaic resources in projecting identity and traumatic experiences of children. Cazanva's (2005) submission is further echoed in Ofosu-Kusi and Abebe (2016) who argue that children are portrayed with multiple and diverse images in African novels. On the socio-economic and psychological plights of street children, Ugwuanyi's (2017) analysis of Amma Darko's *Faceless* and Bulawayo Noviolate's *We Need New Names*, through the postcolonial lens, reveals the environmental, cultural and emotional challenges that confront the African child. Although Adesola (2022) observes that African novelists privilege specific factors in their depiction of child soldering, Ofor (2023) submits that the African child suffers numerous forms of abuse, deprivation and lack as a result of poor leadership. While Kearney (2010) notes that African novelists have constantly reflected the recruitment of the African child in militarism, he equally argues that the resilience of the African children is echoed in the face of daunting socio-economic and political challenges.

From the foregoing, one can safely say that varying perspectives have examined the representation of the African child. This study agrees that existing debates have acknowledged the travails of the African child from different methodological and theoretical viewpoints. However, the depiction of the trauma of the African male child has not enjoyed sufficient literary interrogation. Preference for male childhood trauma is occasioned by the plethora of studies (Ajidahun, 2020; Mohammed, 2010; Murray, 2017; Lugano, 2005; Okpiliya and Archibong, 2021; and Olayiwola and Olowonmi 2013) that have anchored the plights of the female child in Africa environment. Such studies have explored the representation of female child challenges. Some other studies (Donjeta Osmani 2019; Melakneh 2008; Udenweze 2009; Mokry 2011; Nwakanma 2013; Tiffany Astrick 2019; Umarani & Kumaran 2019) have also interrogated literary constitution of patriarchy in African milieu.

Addei (2018), Nabutanyi (2013), Thandokazi (2013), Ouma (2020) have articulated refreshing debates on the pitiable conditions of the African male child in African literary works using postcolonial, affective, psychoanalysis and trauma theories. These studies have not sufficiently interrogated the trope adopted by African writers in depicting the traumatic conditions of male child and understanding the implication of the tragic events on the personhood of the traumatised male child. This contention is premised on the assumption that the male child is naturally imbued with stronger adaptive physical and psychological features which enable him to respond to environmental realities. Therefore, this study believes that Step Crap Trauma theory will offer a fresh approach to this subject. Against this backdrop, this study examines the trope of male childhood trauma in Elnathan John's *Born on a Tuesday* and Ishmael Beah's *A Long Way Gone* with a view to describing the contextual traumatic indices of the African male child.

Theoretical framework: Step Crap's Trauma Theory

Stef Craps' trauma theory emerges as a critique of traditional trauma studies, particularly the works of scholars such as Cathy Caruth, which are largely based on Western experiences of trauma, especially the Holocaust. In *Postcolonial Witnessing: Trauma Out of Bounds* (2013), Craps argues that mainstream trauma theory universalises Western histories of suffering while marginalising the traumatic experiences of non-Western societies. Craps advocates the decolonization of trauma studies by recognizing the diverse forms of trauma experienced in postcolonial societies. According to him, trauma should not be understood solely as an individual psychological condition but also as a collective and historical experience shaped by colonialism, slavery, poverty, displacement, war and state violence. He contends that the suffering of formerly colonised peoples deserves equal critical attention within trauma discourse.

A central aspect of Craps' theory is his emphasis on cross-cultural ethical witnessing. He argues that literary texts can create spaces for empathy and recognition across cultural boundaries by giving voice to marginalised experiences. Thus, postcolonial literature becomes an important medium for representing silenced histories and challenging dominant narratives of suffering. Craps' theory is particularly useful because it enables scholars to examine how trauma is produced by socio-political structures and historical injustices rather than merely personal experiences.

Analysis

The analysis will be anchored in Step Crap's Trauma Theory. The theory advocates the traumatic histories of colonised and marginalised peoples, recognition of historical trauma, emphasis on cultural context and ethical witnessing of marginalised voices. It further situates trauma within broader political and social structures. Given these central tenets, the theory provides a suitable framework for the analysis of the two novels.

1. Examination of the socio-political catalysts of male childhood trauma

Male childhood trauma is represented as a direct product of socio-political instability within postcolonial African societies. Both novels reveal that childhood trauma is not isolated but produced by the collapse of social structures.

Internal institution is the first contributor of male childhood trauma in both novels. The home is the internal institution. The home that should dictate the formation of healthy personalities is destroyed due to religious indoctrination, poor parenting, family trauma and genocide. These indices are responsible for disrupted childhoods, where the home becomes unstable. Both novels portray family instability and emotional neglect. In *BOAT*, Dantala's separation from his family deprives him of emotional affection and parental protection. His father's decision to send Dantala and his brothers "away" contributes significantly to his emotional fragmentation. The concept of Almajiri appears clearer when Dantala returns home after a political unrest and his uncle named Shaibu thunders these words "Dantala! When did you get into town? But you have not been fair, wallahi. Are you the first to be sent away to be an almajiri? (45). The phrase "sent away" captures the reality of deliberate parental negligence at placing their children at the care of a religious leader who is expected to combine spiritual, physical, emotional and moral training. Many of the children are homeless due to wrong indoctrination. It suffices to state that the new father is cumbered with responsibilities greater than his capacity, considering the numerous students. In most cases, the children, while under strict discipline, get ripped off their sense of self and emotional affection due to the survival tactics employed by the new fathers. Thus, familial separation becomes a form of psychological violence that weakens childhood stability and identity formation.

The reader is also aware that his father, despite sending four sons to different Islamic teachers, refrains from taking care of his remaining family members and his wife. The family produces six children without adequate plan and the wife experienced sorrow of motherhood due to separation between her and her sons. This shows that the decision to send the children away was taken by the father. There is no mutual agreement. The patriarchal system that snatches the sons from the mother also deprived her of marital bliss. She is neglected and eventually dies. The death of his mother Umma, also intensifies Dantala's trauma. He bursts his repressed emotion when he says ... "but I am angry at my father for sending us to different places. It scares that I cannot remember him, the things he used to say, his loud voice, but his face is blank in my head" (106). Dantala blames himself and his absent brothers for his mother's suffering: "I am angry my brothers stop visiting Umma...Maybe all our faces put together would have been strong enough to break the chains that kept her mouth sealed" (106–107). He expresses anger towards his father for separating the family and this further reveals the emotional

damage caused by familial fragmentation and displacement. The family eventually gets separated as Dantala's brother practise the radical Shiite version of Islam, while he believes in liberal Islam.

The unstable nature of the initial home and irrational behaviour of his Islamic teacher makes Dantala desire the tutelage of Sheikh. Sheikh becomes the father and leader he never had. Substituted parenting replaces the biological parenting. At the contact with Sheikh, Dantala is mesmerised at the enlightened world and liberal thinking of this leader. At Sokoto, Dantala is immersed into another world that upholds religious sanctity with liberalism. He remembers the two deformed worlds.

Many memories float in my head, Memories of when all of my family was still in one house in Dogon Icce. When Maccido used to pinch me and I would cry and nobody would believe me when I would say what he did. When I used to be angry that the twins got anything they wanted and my father hit Umma, Maccido and me but never them...When in Bayan Layi, Malam Junaidu flogged a boy who couldn't remember his Quaranic flogged a boy who couldn't remember his Quranic verses with his tyre whip (71).

His new experience at Sheikh's place and the hospitality he enjoys is juxtaposed to reflect the torture of his own home and his former foster father, Malam Junaidu. This means Islam, like other religions, manifests two sides of the coin: extremism and liberalism. The reader realises that his parent decision is bore out poverty and lack of proper orientation. Though, Islam permits this form of parenting tagged as Almariji, but does not rule out the involvement of the biological parents. Parents pay the fee and are at liberty to check on their wards. Dantala's teacher mentions the inability of his father to pay after spending six years which means financial responsibility is statutory. Due to the failure of the foster father, the protagonist moves to the street and a member of a gang that comprises street children and children on the street. They engage in alms begging and farming. It could be inferred from the act that the set of people who are exposed to trauma are only in the mosque to receive support. These people are also interested in worshipping God but they are more pressed with a better need which is hunger compelled by circumstance to seek food first before listening to Allah.

...Go to Jumah at the mosque in Sabon Gari on Fridays because there are people giving alms and a lot of free food. But Allah judges the intentions of the heart. We are not terrible people. When we fight, it's because we've to. When we break into small shops in Sabon Gari, it is because we are hungry, and when someone dies, well that is Allah's will. (10-11).

The stigma imposed on them by society often makes it difficult for people to recognise the positive qualities in street children. Nevertheless, some of these children still aspire to a different and better way of life and they should be given this opportunity (Julien, 2024). Here is another instance of search for survival and the struggle over food. "We" the pronominal reference is mapping out identity for this group, creating an identity for them. Dantala defends them by saying "we are not terrible people..." Prior to this time,

there have been contentious about the notorious activities of these street boys with the motif of danger. As peaceful as this group claims, there are instances they fight, and when they fight it is for a purpose, a cause that will benefit them. Hunger makes these people vulnerable to circumstances. If hunger or sickness persists, some of them fall prey to death just like Banda who refuses to cater for his health, even when he has the resources to do so, he prefers to drink and take *weewee* (weed) for daily survival.

In *HOS*, the home is decentralised due to circumstances beyond the protagonist. The home that should provide security is known for physical absence of the biological parents and secrecy. The protagonist experiences neglect, fractured parental relationships and emotional detachment, contributing to psychological instability. Zamani experiences mysterious birth story which is torturous because his childhood is informed by violence and historical trauma. The Gukurahundi massacres reflect the gruesome nature of pre-independent Zimbabwe's and early Zimbabwe's post-independence years. Conceived through rape within a climate of brutality, Zamani's very birth is inscribed within a narrative of violation and coercion. Black Jesus (Zamani's assumed father), the brutal military leader "ordered her (his mother) to lie down and took her on the hard, cold cement floor. Afterwards, the Men in the Red Berets had a go too; they, my many fathers who later tried to smother my provinci-ality" (319). From the story narrated by his uncle, he is certain of his origin due to the similarity in their physical appearance. He is confused about other stories surrounding his conception due to the multiple rapes experienced by the mother.

At the period of his birth, his mother's death wish effectively relinquishes him to the care of his war-scarred uncle, who ensures his physical survival but remains emotionally unavailable. Although the uncle provides material sustenance, he is incapable of offering the affective stability necessary for healthy psychological development because of his own traumatic experience which results into psychological illness. Zamani, therefore, grows up within a fractured familial structure caused by absent paternal guardianship and deprived maternal tenderness.

This absence produces a profound sense of rootlessness. Without a secure foundation of belonging, Zamani internalises abandonment and dislocation, conditions that later manifest in his adult relationships through manipulation, displacement and an obsessive quest for recognition. His existence begins at the epicentre of national conflict; for his safety, he is removed from the violence of Gukurahundi and relocated to his uncle's home. Yet, this migration, though shields him physically, does not resolve the psychological rupture between his traumatic childhood and the eventual death of his uncle. Instead, it leaves a lingering void; an unresolved gap that informs his fractured identity and fuels his destructive attempts to inscribe himself into history. Movement for Zamani at childhood covers his birth narrative, his stay with his uncle, his relocation to London and return to the independent Zimbabwe. This migration shields him from the core danger zone, but does not attend to his inner pain, especially when he is exposed to the real truth.

Migration is also depicted as a feature of contemporary narratives. Characters are moved from one location to the other to portray the journey of the victims. The uncertainty of war brings about movement and survival. Movement receives a negative colouration as it pushes the protagonist towards uncertainty and instability. Same with

Dantala, he encounters a kind of cyclical journey from their home to various unknown destinations. This instability occurs mentally, physically and emotionally and disrupts some happy childhood moments of the protagonists.

Unlike Dantala's visible emotional breakdowns, Zamani internalises fear through self-monitoring and emotional repression. His fear is tied to inherited political violence and the brutality associated with his biological origins. Consequently, fear becomes a permanent psychological condition that shapes his masculinity.

External Institutional Violence is portrayed through religious leadership and sectarian violence, political unrest and Street Government. In *BOAT*, Dantala and other boys are manipulated through religion. The boys in Malam Junaidu's are trained under oppressive structure: they are physically tortured for their inability to remember the Quranic verse. An instance of this is a boy who is flogged with tyre whip and "threw up blood, was taken away and never came back" (55). Just like Malam Junaidu, Malam Abdul Nur does the same to the boys under him. This reveals something about the perpetrators, the two armed with the same tool religion. Their manner of administration compared to Sheikh also uncovers some hidden causes of attitude towards their students which are poverty and narrow mindedness. Dantala's description of the two tutors reveals the unpleasant condition of children under their religious tutors. Thus, the students are not treated as children, so they are perpetually afraid of their masters.

Jibril, the narrator's friend, receives punishments from his Uncle, Malam Abdul-Nur. On two occasions, Dantala also observes him and confides in the reader about Malam Abdul-Nur's personality. Malam Abdul-Nur is described as impatient and hot-tempered and he enjoys hitting people. Each time he sends for Jibril, there is always evidence of beating which makes the narrator question his personality. Dantala reports: "I don't like the way Jibril returns with a red eye or swollen lip many times after his brother has sent for him. Jibril is too old to be beaten like a child. I don't like the way Malam Abdul-Nur hits people (80).

One is not surprised to see Abdul Nur as the prime suspect of Sheikh Jamal's death and the new beneficiary of the Saudi Arabia Islamic grant due to his radical confessions and the need to rule people without emotional regulation. An untamed Abdul Nur becomes a threat to the new neighbourhood where he grooms young boys into militants. Sheikh Jamal exposes that "Some of the worst enemies of Islam are the ones who deceive innocent people into thinking they are Muslims. Somebody who has no understanding of Islam and its precepts..." (217). He says further that Islam does not put people in bondage, nor fear. The novel mentions different sects such as are Salifist, Shiite and the Mujahideen. Based on the wide divide in belief, conflicts that lead to burning of properties and killings happen, leaving Dantala in doubt on the essence of humanity and religion.

Exploitation of vulnerable boys by street management is symbolised by Banda and other gang leaders. As the street leader, he manipulates other children into various forms of vice. Dantala becomes a wanderer and emotionally burdened after his savior's death. "This thought stayed with me for a long time until suddenly a fear gripped me in my chest for questioning Allah and why Banda was destined to die. So I kept saying astaghfirullah...(19) The Bayan Ladi incident coupled with the accident further traumatises him.

The Almariji scheme as a system of parental neglect is portrayed as an institution that places young boys into the hands of foster fathers who are called the Imams. The institution is empowered under the guise of religion. In educating these young boys, the religious leaders with violent spirit can also indoctrinate negatively since he is a model to the young boys. At Sokoto, young boys are grouped into various circles- Sheikl Jamal mosque, the Shiites, the Mujadeheen, the street boys, who commit crime and engage in sexual activities, and the ones who metamorphose into political thugs. All these categories always end up in recycling the system. At a mature stage, they start a family and continue this cycle. Instead of receiving guidance and protection, they become tools in broader systems of violence and power struggles. This exploitation demonstrates how institutions that should nurture children contribute to their trauma and loss of agency.

The last is the interwoven involvement of the government. The government plays a significant role in contributing to Dantala's trauma through neglect, corruption, political violence and the failure of state institutions to protect vulnerable children. Instead of serving as a source of security and social welfare, governmental structures create the conditions that expose Dantala to displacement and psychological instability. The state fails to provide accessible education, welfare and protection for poor northern children. As a result, Dantala grows up in poverty and is forced into street life under the Almajiri system, where children survive through begging and dependence on religious teachers. The government's inability to reform or regulate this system leaves boys like Dantala exposed to lack, exploitation and emotional abandonment. This institutional neglect creates the foundation of his traumatic childhood.

Another important role of the government is seen in political violence and instability. Politicians exploit religious and ethnic tensions for personal gain, while ordinary citizens suffer the consequences. It is obvious that hunger can change the true character. As against Dantala's defence of this class of people, the set of "kuka boys" plus himself have been made mercenaries of evil act by the politicians. "We file past the truck to get our own two-hundred-naira notes and fuel and matches and machetes (12). Deceived to conquer "the Big Party" and promised to live in abundance, Dantala and others become the victims of violent riots that destroy communities and displace innocent people. These violent experiences expose him to death and insecurity at a young age, leaving deep psychological scars. The state's failure to maintain peace and protect citizens contributes directly to his traumatic experiences.

Government corruption also intensifies Dantala's suffering. Public institutions meant to support vulnerable populations are ineffective because leaders prioritise personal interests over public welfare. Poverty, unemployment, and social inequality remain widespread because of poor governance. Thus, children like Dantala lack opportunities for education, healthcare and social development. The harsh socio-economic conditions force him into survival mode, depriving him of the stability and care necessary for healthy childhood development.

Also, the government's weak security and justice systems contribute to an atmosphere of fear and uncertainty. Violence often occurs without accountability, and vulnerable individuals receive little protection. Dantala grows up in an environment where insecurity becomes normal. The absence of effective governmental intervention

allows extremist influences and social disorder to flourish, increasing his emotional and psychological vulnerability.

The government also contributes indirectly to Dantala's identity crisis and emotional isolation. Because state institutions fail to create inclusive opportunities for marginalized youths, Dantala struggles to find belonging and direction. His movement from one unstable environment to another reflects the broader failure of governance in postcolonial society. Instead of nurturing young citizens, the state abandons them to systems of poverty, violence, and manipulation. *BOAT*, therefore, criticises the postcolonial African state for failing to protect vulnerable Dantala.

Both authors employ distinctive narrative techniques to portray the psychological fragmentation of traumatised male characters. In *BOAT*, Elnathan John uses first-person narration to provide intimate access to Dantala's inner consciousness. Through Dantala's voice, readers encounter confusion and insecurity directly. The simplicity of the narration reflects the protagonist's limited educational background and traumatic experiences. This narrative style creates authenticity and allows readers to witness the gradual psychological transformation of the character.

In *HOS*, the external institutions play a crucial role in inducing trauma on Zamani. His psychological confusion and fractured identity are determined not only by personal experiences, but also by oppressive political and historical institutions operating within the Zimbabwean society. It portrays the damage of institutional forces on individual identity and mental stability. The first major external institution that contributes to Zamani's trauma is the government. Set against the background of the Gukurahundi massacres, the government forces violently attacked civilians in Matabeleland. This state-sponsored violence creates an atmosphere of silence and insecurity that affects Zamani's psychological state. The government's abuse of power destroys families and communities, leaving survivors emotionally wounded. Even though Zamani does not directly witness every act of violence, the effects of state terror shape the environment in which he lives and develops. Abednego, Uncle Fani and other men mentioned are silent due to the structural oppression which Zamani inherited.

Could it be that his darkness is in me? But I love Abednego. I wish to know my surrogate father far better than this man who is my father, who cannot be my father; eish, but why, Uncle Fani! Why did he have to confess his secrets to me? Why did he tell- Ah, what is the use of torturing myself with these memories? I'm a man on a new path, after all. By the end of these chronicles of our family hi-story, I shall be born again, into a Mlambo son. I shall have succeeded in escaping the dreadful past bequeathed me by my uncle on his deathbed. (96)

The connection between the Gukurahundi and colonial legacies lies in the way colonialism created the ethnic and structural conditions that later contributed to post-independence violence in Zimbabwe. The Gukurahundi massacres do not emerge in isolation; they are deeply rooted in the divisions established during colonial rule. Under British colonialism in Southern Rhodesia (now Zimbabwe), colonial authority uses divide-and-rule strategies that intensified ethnic tensions, especially between the Shona

and Ndebele groups. Colonial administrators often categorised ethnic groups politically, creating competition among communities. These divisions continued after independence and became part of the political conflicts that later fueled the Gukurahundi violence.

Another important institution inducing trauma is the political system that suppresses truth and historical memory. The government's refusal to openly acknowledge past atrocities creates collective silence and unresolved grief. Zamani grows up in a society where painful histories are hidden or distorted, making it difficult for the citizens to fully comprehend and come to terms with their experiences. This suppression of truth contributes to Zamani's fragmented sense of identity. The inability to confront historical violence prevents healing and prolongs psychological suffering.

In conclusion, Zamani's trauma in *House of Stone* is largely induced by external institutions such as the government, political structures, colonial legacies, and unstable social conditions. These institutions create fear, silence, displacement, deception and identity fragmentation that shape his psychological suffering. Tshuma therefore presents trauma as a product of oppressive institutional forces that continue to affect individuals long after violence has occurred.

2. Implication of Male Childhood on Protagonists

Dantala experiences further disconnection with his family and Sheikh's family. After the destruction of the mosque, he becomes of a victim of mass arrest. In the cell, he is tortured, starved and detained by the military for nine months. He is named black spirit which symbolizes his resilience. By the time he is released, he is physically broken and emotionally damaged. Dantala falls deeply in love with Aisha, Sheikh's daughter. However, he is denied his dream because of his background and power. Aisha eventually marries Alhaji Usman for political and social security, Dantala does not fight it or express rage. "My wife," I say to the two men sitting on a bench just by the sticker....one of them gets up to see what I am pointing at. 'My wife,' I repeat, 'she is my wife.' He hisses when he sees the picture and walks away. His emotional numbing has trained him to accept abandonment or fate as his natural state.

He experiences premature aging and permanent disillusionment. Dantala is only in his early twenties, yet, he is described to look like an old man, wrinkled, thin, bent and deeply consumed by his experiences. His body bears the permanent and physical archive of a traumatised life.

The protagonist experiences loneliness of survival. Although his resilience allows him outlive almost every other character and leaves him alone. His only silver lining is a message scribbled in charcoal by his friend Jibril, hinting at a relationship built on shared survival, rather than stable adult institution. At adulthood, his mentor Banda and surrogate father Sheikh Jamal are both dead. The mosque which symbolizes his relevance and future has been burnt. As aunt Khadijah's advices, he is not introduced into formal western education nor trade because he thinks he is deputised Sheikh but his death snatches the aspiration from him. Therefore, he lands right back on the streets of Sokoto as a displaced person.

In *HOS*, the narration is basically necessitated by his defensive claim at the opening of the work. The use of pronominal identity "I" emphasises the point of view likewise, depicting the forceful nature of the protagonist. "I am a man on a mission. A

vocation, call it, to remake the past, and a wish to fashion all that has been into being and becoming. It all started when my surrogate father, Abednego Mlambo, sought me out in my lodgings two days ago..." (1). As a man on the mission, Zamani is conscious of his state of nothingness and he is conscious of regaining his personhood through any available means. The reader is not surprised by many fabricated tales narrated in his favour. The mission is well identified from the beginning and this drives the reader into the psychological intricacies that compel him to contest for an inheritance to which he has no biological claim. His mission is to be "born again" into an "ideal" family and a wish to integrate himself into a family is his major need. With the first-person narration, the desperation of Zamani is exposed and the reader realises that he is ready to do anything just to achieve this wish at even at adulthood.

I yearn for, a father, my father, my mother, to be somebody's son. Strong family roots in which to build my legacy. Being reminded of this helped to calm me, and I was able to think clearly for the first time in days. I've been feeling terrible, panicking, shrinking from my surrogate parents, all because I haven't been focusing on my redemptive chronicles. Ever since I started gleaning from my surrogate parents their hi-stories, and from this the seeds for my own new hi-story, I have felt myself progress. I have felt an inner change. I am becoming a new person, imbibing fresh stories, a new way of seeing and being, casting away the burdensome identity Uncle Fani thrust upon me on his deathbed. I am beginning, finally, to see the light. (266)

Zamani's inability to trust people or institutions reflect a deeper homelessness, yet he investigates other people's secrets: he has no place where he can fully belong without fear of reprisal. The home, traditionally associated with warmth and protection, is replaced by anxiety and self-censorship. Securing a physical abode is the first thing Zamani identifies by insisting on renting the pygmy in his sold Uncle's building despite all odds.

Secondly, his desperation for belonging is revealed when he reiterates Abednego's acknowledgment of his relationship with his son: "as he said... he appreciated how I had taken his son Bukhosi under my wing, plying big brother and that I was like a son to him and he would, from then on, call me his surrogate son" (1). This longing is reinforced later when he reassures himself with the memory of his surrogate father's words: "To hear him call me 'son,' even if surrogate son, when he sought me out two days ago in my lodgings, was the sweet fruit of a long labour" (7). At another time, Zamani articulates an ideal familial relationship in a manner that confuses the reader. What initially appears to describe affection and cohesion is later revealed as the product of a disillusioned and distorted mindset, shaped by the absence of a genuine family during his upbringing. His understanding of family and love is therefore constructed through longing, imitation and fantasy rather than lived experience, thereby depicting how early deprivation shapes his perception of belonging and relational dynamics.

I wanted to reach out and hold him, but we had never shared such moments, him and I. I had seen him lean into Mama Agnes's embrace... I had also caught him and Bukhosi once, locked in an uncomfortable grip, something

almost like a hug, but not quite, for their faces were held apart even as they squeezed each other's shoulders (2)

The repetition of these statements about his sonship shows the intensity of his need for recognition and familial affiliation. "I wonder what my life would have been like, had I grown up knowing my father...what would it have been like, to grow up knowing my forebears? (15). Thirdly, when he discovers his birth story through Uncle Fani and fragments he gathers from Abed, he resorts to a recreation of an intangible patrilineage which he does not have physical connection with. His understanding of Black Jesus and the brutality he embodies for President Robert Mugabe seems to intoxicate him. At the young age, he confesses his that he would cut off Black Jesus' image but at a adulthood, he reconsiders the importance of biological link based on the father-son relationships that existed between Abed and Bukhosi and he wishes for same.

I had claimed my patrilineage... What do you mean -? The bastard! He sought to destabilised me, I knew, to get me to question myself. But I wouldn't give him the satisfaction. I recovered my poise. "This man is my father. I'm his son. Take a good look, because each time you see me, I want you to understand that you are seeing him (355).

This reveals Zamani's intense struggle for patrilineal legitimacy, a struggle that is inseparable from postcolonial power, trauma, and silencing. His declaration, "I had claimed my patrilineage" shows a desperate attempt to anchor identity within a patriarchal structure that promises belonging and authority despite the brutality done by the biological father and his unrepresentable birth story. However, this claim is immediately rebuffed by Abednego who does not believe his new attachment to a man who subjects him into horror. Although Zamani asserts his voice and lineage, his declaration does not emerge from genuine recognition but from anxiety and defensive self-fashioning. His outburst, "The bastard! He sought to destabilise me", reveals that his speech is reactive rather than emancipatory. His sudden assertion is mediated by power, patriarchy, and inherited trauma; thus, it does not translate into agency. His insistence on being seen as the father's image reflects internalised colonial logic, where legitimacy is achieved through resemblance to authority, not through self-defined identity. Zamani does not dismantle the system that marginalises him; instead, he seeks validation within it.

His weird response depicts unprocessed and inherited trauma. His fear of destabilisation by Abednego "to get me to question myself" shows a fractured self-structured by historical and intergenerational violence. His need to "recover his poise" suggests a performative masculinity developed as a survival mechanism rather than emotional healing. Trauma is not resolved but acted out, compelling Zamani to cling to symbolic gestures of authority and lineage to mask inner vulnerability. His homelessness also produces self-erasure through identification with power. Zamani collapses his identity into that of the father, reproducing the very tyranny and exclusion that traumatised him. There are repetitions of violence rather than recovery when structural conditions foreclose healing.

Conclusion

The study narrates male childhood trauma in *BOAT*, John situates his narrative within the religious and political tensions of Northern Nigeria, where the protagonist, Dantala, becomes entangled in the extremist violence and ideological conflicts in the Northern Nigeria. The novel reveals how poverty, displacement and religious manipulation destroy childhood innocence and transform young boys into instruments of violence. *HOS* explores the haunting legacies of Zimbabwe's Gukurahundi massacres and the psychological debris of postcolonial state violence. Through fragmented narration and haunting silences, Zamani inherits trauma which dictates the masculine identity. In the novel, masculinity becomes burdened with historical memory and its unresolved fear.

In the two texts, the male child operates as a symbolic and material representation of the postcolonial state. The child's vulnerability reflects state fragility while the child's agency reflects social resilience. In African literature, especially in narratives of conflict and political instability, childhood becomes a mirror through which writers critique governance, historical violence, and national identity formation. Thus, the figure of the child is not merely developmental but deeply political, as it depicts the contradictions in the postcolonial African states.

Both novels deploy distinct narrative strategies to represent male childhood trauma as a complex interplay between the overlapping internal and external structures in normalising violence for the male child. A situation where home becomes unstable and the state appears absent or complicit in violence, such will result into deformation. A study of this nature has not only extended the frontiers of scholarship on structures responsible for male childhood trauma in Africa but it has brought to the fore how the male child operates as a symbolic and material representation of the postcolonial state. Also, the study contributes to broader discussions on gender, memory and narrative in contemporary African literature.

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